

Translating International Environmental Agreement into Domestic Policy and Practice

A Comparative Analysis of The Influence of the Paris Agreement in India and France

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I. Introduction

The Paris Agreement, adopted in 2015 under the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), represents a landmark shift in global climate governance. With its aim to limit global temperature rise to below 2 degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels, the Agreement has placed international pressure on countries to establish Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) and align domestic policies accordingly. This comparative analysis explores how the Paris Agreement has influenced environmental policymaking in India and France, examining how these diverse political landscapes interpret, implement, and negotiate international obligations domestically. We focus on the two countries' distinct economic, political, and energy contexts to assess how much NDCs influence domestic policies and identify factors that facilitate or impede this translation. Further, we consider the role of media, public opinion, historical path dependency, and institutional influence over decision-makers in each country, providing insight into the localized impact of a global treaty. By analyzing policy evolution, implementation, and alignment with NDCs, the paper aims to offer actionable insights for policymakers on overcoming barriers, promoting innovations, and ensuring the effective execution of global climate agreements.

II. Research Background

A. Overview

International agreements, particularly those concerning human rights and environmental protections, exert significant influence over domestic policy when countries translate these into actionable national frameworks. According to the Foundations of Global Health and Human Rights, international treaties create obligations that states domestically internalize through legislation, policymaking, education, and judicial practices ^[1]. The Paris Agreement extends beyond mere symbolic commitments by embedding a framework for regular review and reporting that pushes states toward transparency and accountability ^[2]. However, challenges remain in aligning these obligations with diverse national interests and capacities.

B. Global History

The 20th century marked significant milestones in International environment agreements (As shown in Table 1).

Table 1- Timeline of Important Paris Agreement Milestones

Year	Event	Significance	Countries Involved
1992	Adoption of the UNFCCC at the Earth Summit in Rio de Janeiro	Established the principle of "common but differentiated responsibilities" (CBDR).	All UN member states
1997	Kyoto Protocol adopted	Legally binding emission reduction targets for developed countries; excluded developing nations.	Primarily developed nations
2007	Bali Action Plan	Outlined a roadmap for a post-2012 climate agreement to include all nations.	All UNFCCC members
2015	Adoption of the Paris Agreement	First universal climate agreement with voluntary NDCs and a goal to limit warming to below 2°C.	196 countries
2019	European Green Deal launched	Comprehensive EU strategy for achieving net-zero emissions by 2050	European Union
2020	China pledges carbon neutrality by 2060	Major step for the largest emitter; announcement spurred momentum for other large economies to follow suit.	China
2021	COP26 in Glasgow	Countries strengthened NDCs and committed to phase out coal and halt deforestation.	Global (e.g., India pledged net-zero by 2070).
2023	Loss and Damage Fund agreed at COP27	Established a financial mechanism to support vulnerable countries impacted by climate change.	Global

III. Literature Review

Mechanisms of Influence on Domestic Policies

The Paris Agreement introduces a series of mechanisms designed to influence domestic environmental policies and stimulate sustainable development on national and local scales.

1. Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) as a Policy Framework

NDCs are the centrepiece of the Paris Agreement's influence on domestic policy. The Agreement encourages countries to incorporate climate objectives into national planning by requiring each signatory to submit specific climate targets and strategies. Each NDC reflects a country's domestic priorities, political realities, and economic conditions, enabling nations to set feasible goals for emissions reductions, renewable energy development, and climate adaptation. For instance, India's NDC under the Paris Agreement includes ambitious targets for expanding renewable energy capacity and improving energy efficiency in various sectors ^[3].

NDCs are a tool for harmonizing international commitments with local actions. As countries revise and submit updated NDCs every five years ^[4], the mechanism encourages adaptation to changing scientific insights, economic developments, and technological innovations.

2. Regular Reporting and Transparency Mechanisms

The Paris Agreement's transparency framework establishes a robust system for monitoring and verifying each country's progress toward its NDCs. The framework incentivizes countries to align their domestic policies with international commitments by requiring regular emissions reporting and adaptation tracking ^[5]. Additionally, these reports undergo a technical review by experts, providing a feedback loop to identify best practices, gaps, and areas for improvement.

Transparency mechanisms aim to build an environment of accountability and trust, as countries can compare efforts and draw inspiration from effective policies implemented by their peers. For example, European countries, including France, regularly report on emissions data, energy efficiency standards, and renewable energy targets. The transparency framework is particularly influential in federal systems, such as the USA, where individual states can align with or exceed national targets, and in large, decentralized democracies like India, where state-level actions complement national efforts.

3. Financial Support and Technological Assistance

A core challenge for developing countries in meeting climate targets is funding availability and access to advanced technologies. The Paris Agreement addresses this issue by institutionalizing financial and technical support for low- and middle-income countries ^[6]. This framework supports adaptation measures, such as building climate-resilient infrastructure and transitioning to clean energy systems.

The Green Climate Fund, an outcome of previous climate negotiations under the UNFCCC ^[7], provides financial resources to assist countries in reducing GHG emissions and adapting to

climate impacts. By offering grants, loans, and capacity-building initiatives, the GCF and related financial mechanisms aim to bridge the resource gap between developed and developing nations, encouraging equitable climate action. Countries like India, which face significant adaptation challenges, benefit from these funds to support projects like solar energy expansion and climate-resilient agricultural practices.

4. Stocktake and Review Processes

The global stocktake is a periodic assessment of collective progress toward achieving the Paris Agreement's long-term goals. By reviewing the combined efforts of all parties, the stocktake provides valuable insights into areas where the Agreement's ambitions still need to be met, thereby encouraging countries to enhance their domestic efforts. This review process also plays a crucial role in advancing climate science, as findings from the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) and other research bodies inform countries of evolving best practices and necessary action points.

The stocktake process and periodic review cycle are designed to increase ambition over time. As countries observe peers' achievements or recognize where targets are being missed, they are incentivized to refine and intensify domestic policies. Thus, the transparency and stocktake mechanisms operate in tandem to transform international goals into actionable and measurable domestic policies.

IV. Methodology

1. Case Study Approach

A. Justification for Selecting India and France

India and France were selected due to their contrasting economic, political, and energy profiles, which provide a comprehensive perspective on the global influence of the Paris Agreement.

France and India represent contrasting political systems and energy priorities: As an emerging economy and the world's third-largest greenhouse gas emitter, India offers insights into the challenges faced by resource-constrained nations in balancing economic growth, energy security, and climate commitments. Its reliance on coal for nearly 70% of its electricity ^[8] generation contrasts with its ambitious renewable energy targets, making it a compelling case to explore the tensions between development and sustainability. Conversely, France, a developed nation and host of the 2015 COP21 conference ^[9], represents a leader in international climate diplomacy with a robust commitment to carbon neutrality by 2050. Its reliance on nuclear power, which accounts for over 70% of its electricity, provides a unique pathway for low-emission energy transition ^[10]. This comparison illuminates pathways through which countries integrate NDCs into domestic policy.

B. Data Collection

- **Policy Documents and Case Studies:** Primary data sources include government publications, such as *India's Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MOEFCC)* reports, which

show an exponential increase in renewable energy installations since 2015 ^[11], and the *French Environment and Energy Management Agency (ADEME)* reports, which track the progress of renewable energy targets.

- News and Media Coverage: Analysis of media reports, editorials, and opinion pieces from policy debates. Examples include *UNFCCC announcements*, *The Hindu* and *Le Monde*.
- Government Documents and Legislative Reviews: India's National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC) and state-level policies; France's Energy Transition for Green Growth Act and Climate Energy Plan.
- Academic and Policy Studies: Scholarly articles and books on climate policy further contextualise domestic legislative measures within the broader environmental policy landscape.

C. Research Objectives

- Timing of Policy Change: Analyzing how long each country took to implement relevant policy changes.
- Political Leadership: Assessing the role of key leaders and interest groups.
- Public Opinion and Media Influence: Comparing the role of public support and media framing in shaping the policy debate.
- Opposition and Advocacy: Examining the strategies of opposition groups (e.g., the Agricultural Unions in India and Far-Right Political Parties in France) versus climate advocacy coalitions.

2. Limitations of the Study

Generalizability: The findings are specific to India and France and may not fully apply to other contexts with different political or cultural dynamics.

Bias in Sources: Media and advocacy materials present subjective viewpoints, requiring careful triangulation with other data.

V. Case Studies

India and France have made significant progress in fulfilling their commitments under the Paris Agreement, although meeting more ambitious targets remains challenging. In Tables 5-1 and 5-2, we compare and describe some of those commitments and challenges in detail.

Table 5-1 India's Paris Agreement commitments and progress

Commitment	Progress	Challenges
Reduction of Emissions Intensity of GDP	Reduce carbon intensity by 33-35% by 2030, compared to 2005 levels. Achieved a reduction of 24% between 2005 and 2020 ^[12] .	Delayed progress: Infrastructure constraints, electricity transmission losses in rural areas and outdated infrastructure can lead to inefficiencies that slow emissions reductions.
Renewable Energy Capacity	Achieve 175 GW by 2022 and 500 GW by 2030. Surpassed 175 GW target by the end of 2024 with significant investments in solar, wind, and hydro. Achieved 50% non-fossil fuel installed capacity milestone.	Solar & Wind Focus: While solar and wind are growing, issues like grid infrastructure and energy storage ^[13] may hinder rapid scaling to meet the 500 GW by 2030 target.
Forest Carbon Sink (Green India Mission & CAF Act)	Sequester an additional 2.5-3 billion tons of CO ₂ by 2030. The Green India Mission (GIM) aims to increase forest and tree cover on 5 million hectares of land while improving the quality of existing forests on an additional 5 million hectares. ^[14]	Monitoring Challenges: Effective implementation and monitoring of the afforestation and carbon sequestration activities may be inconsistent in some regions ^[15] .
State-Level Initiative- Khavda Renewable Energy Park	Total capacity of 30 GW, expected to power 16.1 million homes ^[16] and prevent 58 million tonnes of CO ₂ emissions annually.	Implementation Delays: Construction and scaling of such a large energy park may face delays due to land acquisition, infrastructure, and
State-Level Initiatives- Radhanesda Ultra Mega Solar Park	700 MW capacity, significant contributor to Gujarat's renewable energy output, with additional phases under development ^[17] .	Phase Completion Delays: Expansion phases may face delays, impacting overall contribution to the 500 GW renewable target.
Majhi Vasundhara Program	In the first year, 21.94 lakh (2.1 million) trees planted, 83 green areas created, 10,663 tonnes of compost generated per month, leading to 63,982.5 tonnes of CO ₂ sequestration. ^[18]	Urban Coverage: Expanding coverage of green areas and tree planting across more urban areas may be slow due to urbanization pressures and resource constraints.

“We have opened a new chapter of hope in the lives of 7 billion people on the planet. Gandhiji used to say that “we have not inherited earth from our ancestors, but we have it on loan from future generations.” We have today reassured our future generation that we all together will mitigate the challenge posed by climate change and we will give them a better future. I thank and congratulate French Presidency for vision, patience and firmness with which you handled this COP. The result is today's historical agreement.”

- PRAKASH JAVADEKAR, INDIAN ENVIRONMENT MINISTER ^[19]

“Signing the Paris Agreement aims to avoid tragedies. Climate change driven disasters, misery. We need to respond to the emergency.”

- Francois Hollande, President of France ^[20]

Table 5-2 France's Paris Agreement commitments and progress

Commitment	Target/Progress	Challenges
Reduction of Emissions Intensity of GDP	France committed to reducing greenhouse gas emissions by 40% by 2030 compared to 1990 levels. The 2030 target will be revised shortly to bring it into line with the new European 2030 objective of -55% net ^[21] .	Economic Activity & Emissions: Growth in transportation and industry sectors, especially air travel and freight, may slow down the emission reductions needed.
Renewable Energy Capacity	France aims to reach 40% of renewable energy in its energy mix by 2030. By 2020, renewable energy was about 19% of the country's energy mix ^[22] .	Transition Slowdown: The pace of transitioning from nuclear and fossil fuels to renewable energy has been slower than expected, particularly in offshore wind development.
Coal Phase-Out	France completed its goal to phase out coal-fired power plants by 2022, aligning with its emissions reduction targets.	Energy Security: Phasing out coal while maintaining reliable energy supply during high demand periods could be challenging, requiring a transition to other sources like gas or renewable

Forest Carbon Sink (Afforestation Programs)	France has committed to increasing forest cover as part of its efforts to achieve carbon neutrality by 2050. Forests in France sequester about 7.5% of the country's annual emissions ^[23] .	Forest Management: Effective monitoring and maintenance of forest ecosystems to enhance carbon sequestration may face challenges, especially in balancing land use.
Transportation and Mobility	France aims to reduce transport-related emissions by promoting electric vehicles (EVs) and public transportation. By 2022, France had 700,000 electric vehicles on the road, with a target of 7 million by 2030.	EV Adoption and Charging Infrastructure: Expanding EV adoption depends on the scaling of charging infrastructure, as well as consumer demand and pricing challenges.
Energy Efficiency	France aims to reduce its energy consumption by 50% by 2030, relative to 1990 levels ^[24] . The country has made steady progress in improving energy efficiency, particularly in residential and industrial sectors.	Efficiency Gains: Achieving substantial savings in energy demand may be constrained by the pace of energy-efficient technologies' adoption in buildings and industry.

The legislative process

We will examine the legislative process and initiatives involved in translating an NDC into domestic policy, focusing on one specific initiative in detail. This will include a breakdown of the key legislative steps and mechanisms involved. We take India's commitment to increase its renewable energy capacity as an example from its NDCs under the Paris Agreement. The commitment was to achieve 175 GW of renewable energy capacity by 2022 and 500 GW by 2030 ^[25]. As a member of the European Union, France has committed to achieving carbon neutrality by 2050 and reducing greenhouse gas emissions by 40% by 2030, compared to 1990 levels ^[26].

Translation of India's Renewable Energy Target into Domestic Policy

Behind India's renewable energy capacity targets involves a complex framework of policies, laws, and government strategies to promote and accelerate the transition to clean energy. The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) is the decision-maker in formulating policies and setting ambitious renewable energy targets. Legislative actions, such as the Renewable Energy Policy (2015) (see Table 5-3), have laid the foundation for increasing renewable capacity, while the National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC) incorporates the National Mission for Enhanced Energy Efficiency to support renewable energy growth further ^[27].

The government has introduced financial mechanisms like the FAME India Scheme (Faster Adoption and Manufacturing of Hybrid and Electric Vehicles) and other incentives for clean energy projects to attract private investment. Funding and subsidies, such as those provided

through the State Renewable Energy Fund, have bolstered renewable energy initiatives. Infrastructure development is another critical focus area, with the Ministry of Power and the Central Electricity Authority (CEA) working to expand the national grid and invest in green corridors to enhance renewable energy transmission, mainly from solar and wind sources ^[28].

India's National Solar Mission, launched in 2010, was initially set to achieve 20 GW of solar capacity by 2022. However, in alignment with its Paris Agreement commitments, the target was scaled up to 100 GW by 2022 ^[29]. As of September 2024, India is on track to add a record 35 GW of solar and wind energy capacity by March 2025, further solidifying its position as a leader in renewable energy production.

At the state level, individual renewable energy policies, such as those in Tamil Nadu and Gujarat, align with national goals. Maharashtra has undertaken urban waste management initiatives, such as the waste-to-energy project in Mumbai, to reduce landfill waste and lower methane emissions ^[30]. States are encouraged to set specific renewable energy targets, while State Electricity Regulatory Commissions (SERCs) introduce regulatory measures and tariff structures to integrate renewable energy into local grids. The legal framework supporting these initiatives includes Renewable Energy Purchase Obligations (RPOs), mandated under the Electricity Act of 2003, which require utilities to procure a portion of their energy from renewable sources ^[31]. Regular updates and amendments to the Electricity Act and the National Electricity Policy ensure the alignment of renewable energy objectives with broader clean energy goals.

Monitoring and reporting mechanisms play a crucial role in tracking progress. The MNRE periodically reviews renewable energy capacity to evaluate its contribution toward the 500 GW target. Compliance mechanisms, such as Renewable Energy Certificates (RECs), enable the verification of renewable energy generation and ensure accountability in achieving renewable energy targets ^[32]. This comprehensive approach underscores India's commitment to transitioning toward a sustainable and clean energy future.

Policy/Legislation	Overview	Significance/Impact
The Electricity Act of 2003 & National Tariff Policy, 2006	Established a regulatory framework for electricity generation, distribution, and transmission. Encourages states to develop renewable energy sources and sets renewable purchase obligations (RPOs). Facilitates Renewable Energy Certificates (RECs).	Supports renewable energy growth, providing utilities mechanisms for meeting renewable energy targets. The Electricity (Amendment) Bill, 2020 (if passed) will further encourage renewable energy integration, energy storage, and cross-border electricity trade.
National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC), 2008	Laid the foundation for India's climate action strategy. Introduced the National Solar Mission (NSM) as a key component, emphasizing renewable energy development.	Influenced the creation of policies and investment incentives to meet renewable energy targets. Marked the beginning of a focused effort on scaling up renewable energy.
The Renewable Energy Policy and Targets	Key policies include the National Solar Mission (2010), Wind Energy Policy (2015), The Renewable Energy Policy (2015) and Hydropower Policy (2016) [33]. These set specific capacity-building targets and provided private sector incentives like tax breaks and faster clearances.	Encouraged private sector participation in renewable energy projects and aimed at achieving ambitious renewable energy capacity targets.
The National Renewable Energy Act (Under Draft)	Aims to formalize India's commitment to renewable energy through long-term integration, grid stability, and investment incentives.	Expected to provide legal clarity for project developers, investors, and state agencies, and strengthen the regulatory framework for attracting renewable energy investments.

Table 5-3 India's Domestic Policies in the Renewable Energy Sector

Translation of France's Coal Phase-Out Target into Domestic Policy

In its initial NDC, the government pledged to phase out coal-fired power plants by 2022, demonstrating its commitment to carbon neutrality. The phase-out was implemented through

strict policy measures, including emissions limits, investment in alternative energy sources, and targeted financial support for transitioning coal-dependent regions and workers ^[34].

In tandem with phasing out coal, France has significantly increased its renewable energy capacity. By 2022, renewable energy accounted for 27% of the nation's total energy consumption, with plans to achieve 40% renewable electricity by 2030. Policies to promote offshore wind farms, solar energy projects, and community-driven renewable initiatives have been integral to this progress. National energy plans and funding mechanisms, such as feed-in tariffs and green certificates, have consistently supported renewable energy adoption.

France has implemented a robust carbon pricing mechanism to ensure a broader transition to a low-carbon economy, including a carbon tax on fossil fuels. It is also a leader in green finance ^[35], advocating for measures like the European Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) to prevent carbon leakage and promote decarbonization across industries. These financial instruments incentivize clean energy investments and encourage industries to adopt sustainable practices, supporting France's climate neutrality goal by 2050.

Complementing mitigation efforts, France has prioritized adaptation strategies to enhance resilience against climate change impacts. These include strengthening flood defenses, promoting sustainable land use, and investing in biodiversity conservation. France's National Adaptation Plan outlines detailed measures to protect vulnerable communities and ecosystems, ensuring alignment with international commitments.

V. Analysis and Discussion

1. Factors That Accelerated Compliance in France

Economic Development: France's financial stability supports significant investments in renewable energy and climate adaptation, while India's focus on poverty alleviation and economic growth constrains resources for climate action. India's advocacy for increased international financing underscores the need for global support to bridge resource gaps ^[36].

Public Support: France enjoys widespread public support for climate initiatives but faces pushback on economically burdensome policies like the fuel tax, exemplified by the "Yellow Vest" protests ^[37]. Urban public awareness about air pollution in India is growing, but rural regions prioritize economic over environmental concerns ^[38].

Political Will: France's centralized governance enables swift climate policy enactment, backed by its long-standing climate diplomacy efforts. While in India, even though national-level political will is substantial, state-level variations in priorities and capacities create inconsistencies in policy execution.

2. Path Dependency and Policy Challenges

India's Coal Dependency: Coal powers 70% of India's electricity, offering energy security but impeding emissions reductions. Transitioning to renewables while maintaining economic growth and jobs in coal-reliant regions is challenging. Programs like the National Solar Mission show progress, but significant international investment and technology transfer are needed for deeper change.

France's Nuclear Dependency: France's reliance on nuclear energy ensures low emissions but limits renewable integration. Plans to reduce nuclear dependence from 75% to 50% by 2035 face financial, technical, and political hurdles ^[39]. Nuclear waste management protests and safety debates further complicate policy evolution ^[40].

3. Aspects Missing from the Paris Agreement That India and France Address

- **Localized Climate Action:** State-level Climate Action Plans allow tailored responses, offering a framework that could enhance the Paris Agreement's subnational reporting mechanisms.
- **Public Acceptance and Social Equity:** France's challenges with public resistance highlight the need to integrate social equity into climate policies, balancing environmental goals with economic realities.
- **Sector-Specific Targets:** The detailed targets in France and India's Climate Energy Plans for EV adoption and energy efficiency provide a granular approach absent in the Paris Agreement's broader framework. For example, as part of the green planning work, the French authorities envisage targets of 66 % of electric cars, 51 % of light electric vehicles, and 50 % of heavy-duty vehicles in new sales in 2030 ^[41].

4. Aspects Missing from India and France That the Paris Agreement Offers

- **Accountability and Adaptation Focus:** Standardized reporting frameworks from the Paris Agreement enhance transparency, which India could apply more rigorously at the state level. The Paris Agreement's emphasis on resilience and adaptation could be better integrated into France's policies in vulnerable regions.
- **International Collaboration:** Mechanisms like the Green Climate Fund provide essential resources for scaling India's renewable energy and adaptation projects.
- **Flexibility for Developing Nations:** While CBDR provides flexibility for developing nations, France's rigid domestic policies lack similar provisions, increasing resistance to ambitious measures.

VII. Conclusion

Domestic political dynamics, including public opinion and economic interests, are crucial in shaping each country's approach to fulfilling climate commitments under the Paris Agreement.

Political priorities, economic factors, and societal attitudes influence how India and France align their domestic policies with international climate goals.

The Paris Agreement has transformed domestic environmental policies in India and France, showcasing how international commitments can be adapted to diverse national contexts. In India, the Agreement has spurred significant progress in renewable energy through initiatives like the National Solar Mission while exposing challenges related to economic constraints, coal dependency, and the need for equitable international financing. France, on the other hand, demonstrates the impact of strong political will and public support. India's legislative framework for meeting its Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) to renewable energy emphasises coordinated efforts across national and state governments. This includes policy formulation, financial mechanisms, infrastructure development, and legal frameworks. Key components such as the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE), state-level policies, the Electricity Act, and renewable energy purchase obligations collectively advance progress toward renewable energy targets.

Both nations underscore how historical dependencies, governance structures, and economic realities shape the translation of international agreements into actionable domestic policies. India's federal system and developmental priorities necessitate decentralized, region-specific approaches, while France's centralized governance enables cohesive national strategies with active engagement from subnational actors and civil society. Despite these efforts, equity, enforcement, and public acceptance challenges highlight the limitations of the Paris Agreement's voluntary framework and the need for more substantial binding commitments and enhanced financial support.

This comparative analysis highlights that while international environment agreements such as the Paris Agreement offer essential guidance, their practical implementation depends on harmonizing global ambitions with local capabilities, ensuring equitable resource distribution, and securing public and political support. Insights from India and France highlight the need for flexible, inclusive, and transparent frameworks to tackle the multifaceted challenge of climate change.

Future research could focus on two key areas to deepen understanding and enhance the effectiveness of international climate agreements. First, generalization across diverse national contexts could provide insights into how various political, economic, and social dynamics influence the translation of international commitments into domestic policies. This would facilitate the design of more universally applicable frameworks for implementing climate goals. Second, in-depth local analyses could shed light on the regional and subnational factors shaping climate policy outcomes. Such analyses can also highlight the importance of community engagement, equitable resource distribution, and tailored financial mechanisms to support climate action at the grassroots level.

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